occasionally public, investment in amenities such as common toilets. As the migrants become more permanent, they bring their families in from their ancestral villages. This leads to an interesting supply-side response—the ‘English Medium’ school! In my experience, language is seen by the poor as the single most important tool for social climbing. Nathupur village in Gurgaon, circa 2009–10, was an example of a village in this second stage.

After another ten to fifteen years, the village goes through a third transformation. By this time, the surrounding area is well settled and open agricultural fields are a distant memory. We now see students, salesmen, and small businessmen move into the village. Some of them may be the newly educated children of migrants but they are now a higher social class. The old villagers still continue to be the dominant owners of the land but they begin to invest in improving their individual properties in order to elicit higher rents (after all, they now have a location advantage in the middle of an established city). In many instances, the owners have become politically important enough to lobby for public investment in basic drainage and sanitation. The shops upgrade themselves and the old street-food-sellers become cheap restaurants. An ‘Aggarwal Sweets’ is almost obligatory in the larger settlements.

The final stage of transformation is that the old village gentrifies. This can happen in a number of ways. Since the early nineties, Hauz Khas village has become a warren of boutique shops, art galleries and trendy restaurants. Mahipalpur, near the international airport, has seen an explosion of cheap hotels in the last decade. Anyone driving to or from the airport will have seen the screaming neon signs that remind one of Hong Kong’s Wan Chai district. Similarly, Shahpur Jat has become home to numerous small offices and designer workshops. In many cases, the old villagers have encashed their real estate and the ownership pattern has become much more mixed. The areas now grapple with the problems of prosperity such as inadequate parking.

Out of this messy process of migration, social-climbing and urban evolution, a new India is emerging. It will be dominated by the newly middle class children of migrants. The country’s old middle class was the